



Nerves of steel: Arshdeep Singh dismissed dangermen Aiden Markram (**above**) and Quinton de Kock and also kept his cool in the penultimate over to give away only four runs. K. R. DEEPAK

year, that's tremendous work."

Powell is right. Since March last year, West Indies has won multiple series against South Africa (away), India, England, and South Africa (at home). Even in its only series defeat, against Australia, its batters racked up scores of 202, 207, and 220. This is a side that can challenge for the title in the future, led by the likes of Nicholas Pooran, Powell, Akeal Hosein, and Alzarri Joseph.

Meanwhile, co-host USA's dream run to the Super 8s will remain one of the lasting moments of this tournament, and its win over Pakistan a seminal event. Having already won its first match at a T20 World Cup by beating Canada, USA held its nerve in a Super Over to defeat the 2022 finalist. USA even ran South Africa close in its opening Super 8 match before being comprehensively beaten by West Indies and England.

By qualifying for the Super 8s, the

USA secured direct entry to the next edition in 2026. However, it currently has no fixtures planned against major cricketing nations before that tournament. Securing victories against stronger teams will be a top priority, but the players also need to adapt to different conditions.

The drop-in wickets at Nassau County International Cricket Stadium drew criticism for their poor quality, leading to low-scoring matches. This was evident after just two games at the venue, with South Africa bowling Sri Lanka out for 77 — its lowest T20 score — and India dismissing Ireland for 96. Consequently, the toss in New York became pivotal, with the team bowling first gaining a significant advantage. Eight of the 16 matches in the USA leg were allotted to New York, which included the marquee India vs Pakistan match. It is thus evident that besides investment in talent, USA also needs to up its game when it comes to the holistic upliftment of cricket infrastructure to compete with the best.

The World Cup was illuminated by many more such remarkable moments. Like when Afghanistan killed two birds with one stone by

defeating Bangladesh, thereby knocking both Bangladesh and Australia out of the tournament. Afghanistan's first semifinal appearance in an ICC event reaffirms its remarkable progress since qualifying for the T20 World Cup for the first time in 2010. Another highlight was Uganda's qualification and participation in its maiden T20 World Cup, having risen through the ranks in the Africa Qualifier. On the other hand, the early exits of Pakistan and Sri Lanka in the first round should prompt introspection regarding their team compositions and strategies. There is a compelling case to be made here for this being one of the most engaging tournaments in recent years, with an expanded pool of 20 teams. While there's still work to be done in terms of scheduling matches, engaging a wider audience, and enhancing the spectator experience, the excitement and unpredictability of the competition were undeniable.

After nearly a month of traversing the Americas and playing 55 matches, the fact that the winner was decided on the last ball of the final is a win for the sport.